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MARITIME SECURITY RISK ASSESSMENT

MERCHANT SHIPPING IN THE RUSSIAN BLACK SEA REGION

Flag-neutral, region-wide assessment
Black Sea, Kerch Strait approaches and Sea of Azov
15 to 27 July 2026

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Merchant shipping in the Russian Black Sea region

Flag-neutral, region-wide assessment · 15 to 27 July 2026

Assessment period	15 July 2026 to 27 July 2026 (assessment date).
Question addressed	Whether, and to what extent, the security risk to merchant shipping operating in the Russian Black Sea region has changed since 15 July 2026, assessed without reference to any individual flag, owner or port.
Bottom line	Risk has increased sharply and remains elevated. One tanker in eleven entering the region since 15 July has been struck. The threat is a declared, named and continuing Ukrainian campaign, and since 15 July it has fallen on mainstream export tonnage bound for international markets, not, as the campaign's own stated aims might suggest, on Crimea resupply traffic alone.

Key judgements

KJ1. A declared Ukrainian campaign against shipping serving Russian ports entered the Black Sea on 15 July and is continuing.

Operation MoLoChKa is conducted by Ukraine's Unmanned Systems Forces, began in the Sea of Azov on 6 July and was publicly extended into the Black Sea on 15 July. Its commander has stated it will continue indefinitely. This is a campaign directed at a trade rather than at particular ships, and it should be expected to persist.

KJ2. The Black Sea phase is striking export tonnage bound for international markets.

The campaign's stated aims centre on the feeder fleet supplying occupied Crimea, and that is what was struck in the Sea of Azov during the first phase. Since the extension into the Black Sea on 15 July the observed target set is different: vessels lifting cargo at the eastern export terminals for onward carriage to third countries. Declared destinations among casualties include Houston, Cape Town, Istanbul, Turkish ports and the Bosphorus for orders, and one Suezmax was struck carrying a cargo of Kazakh crude consigned to a US oil major and loaded through the pipeline-consortium terminal. No recorded casualty was on a Crimea resupply voyage.

KJ3. One tanker in eleven entering the region since 15 July has been struck.

Ten of the 111 tankers and gas carriers recorded in the region between 15 and 27 July were attacked. Casualties across all merchant types rose from around three or four a month to around twelve a week. For a vessel on a three-day call the risk of being struck rose from about 0.3% to about 4%.

KJ4. Bulk carriers have entered the target set. They were not previously in it.

One bulk carrier was struck serving a Russian port in the six and a half months to 14 July. Five were struck in the following twelve days.

KJ5. Registry offers no protection and no additional exposure.

Casualties since 15 July are spread across nine registries, including the largest open registries, several minor ones and a national flag. No registry's record can be distinguished from the others once the volume of traffic under each is taken into account. The same held before 15 July.

KJ6. Neither sanctions status, ownership quality nor vessel age confers protection.

One of the sixteen vessels struck since 15 July carried a sanctions designation. Casualties include tonnage beneficially owned in Greece, Germany, Bermuda, Türkiye, China and Vietnam, and ships delivered in 2024 and 2026.

KJ7. Around half the exposed fleet has already left, and the withdrawal is confined to the classes being struck.

Tanker presence in the region fell by two thirds and bulk carrier presence by half between the two periods, while total merchant presence fell only 16%. General cargo and coastal traffic continued much as before.

KJ8. Vessels are being disabled rather than sunk, and that appears to be deliberate.

Damage is concentrated in hull, machinery and steering, and in fires. Recorded deaths and injuries in this trade are low. The campaign's commander has stated that vessels are struck without being sunk and left drifting. The dominant exposure is therefore salvage, towage, off-hire and cargo delay rather than loss of life or total loss.

1. The threat

1.1 The campaign

The escalation observed from mid-July is the maritime component of a declared Ukrainian campaign against shipping supporting Russian trade. It is conducted by Ukraine's Unmanned Systems Forces under their commander Robert Brovdi and is publicly named Operation MoLoChKa. Brovdi has stated that the name is formed from the initial letters of the Ukrainian phrase "Moscow will fall through Crimea", and that it also reads as everyday slang for dairy products.

The operation began on 6 July 2026 and was initially confined to the Sea of Azov. Brovdi announced on 15 July that it had been extended into the Black Sea. That announcement coincides exactly with the change visible in the casualty record, which means the date is fixed by the party conducting the campaign rather than inferred. He has said the operation will continue indefinitely.

1.2 Stated intent, and what is actually being struck

The stated object is to paralyse the feeder fleet that moves Russian oil and supplies occupied Crimea. That describes the first phase accurately. In the Sea of Azov from 6 July the vessels struck were small coastal tankers, tugs, dry cargo ships and ferries, the domestic and Crimea-facing logistics fleet.

The Black Sea phase since 15 July has a different target set, and the distinction is the most commercially important point in this assessment. The vessels struck are mainstream export tonnage: crude and product tankers lifting at the eastern terminals, and bulk carriers loading for onward voyages. Declared destinations among casualties include Houston, Cape Town, Istanbul, several Turkish ports and the Bosphorus for orders. One Suezmax was struck while working a cargo of Kazakh crude consigned to a US oil major through the pipeline-consortium terminal, a cargo that is neither Russian-owned nor Russian-origin. No casualty in the record was on a Crimea resupply voyage.

The practical consequence is that the campaign's stated purpose is not a reliable guide to its scope. A vessel is exposed because of where it is and what it is doing there, loading or waiting to load at a Russian Black Sea terminal, or transiting to or from one. Whether its cargo ultimately serves Crimea, Russia or a third country has no observable bearing on whether it is struck. An owner who reasons from the operation's name or from its declared aims will understate exposure substantially.

What the stated intent does reliably indicate is character. The campaign is economic rather than lethal in design: Brovdi has stated that vessels are struck without being sunk and left drifting, which corresponds closely to the damage pattern in the record and shapes the consequence profile at Section 5.

1.3 Method and reach

Attacks are delivered principally by uncrewed aerial and surface vehicles. Observed reach extends well beyond port approaches: casualties have occurred more than 250 km from the nearest Russian port and inside the Turkish exclusive economic zone. Ukrainian sources claim well in excess of 170 vessels struck across both seas since 6 July; the verified record is considerably smaller and is what this assessment relies on.

The International Maritime Organization formally condemned the attacks on merchant shipping on 13 July 2026. Russia issued a navigational warning to all vessels in its Black Sea exclusive economic zone on 22 July and has redeployed drone and air-defence units to the two seas.

2. What has changed

Both measures below are drawn from a single consolidated casualty record covering 1 January to 23 July 2026, so they are directly comparable with one another.

2.1 How often vessels are being struck

Period	Length	Casualties	Frequency
1 January – 14 July	195 days	23	one every 8.5 days
15 – 23 July	9 days	16	one every 13 hours

In plainer terms, the tempo went from three or four casualties a month to around twelve a week, roughly fifteen times as often.

2.2 Risk to an individual vessel

Frequency describes how active the campaign is. It is not the same as the risk to a particular ship, because the number of vessels present to be struck has fallen sharply over the same period. Counting casualties against the time vessels actually spent in the region gives the following.

Class	Risk per day, before	Risk per day, after	Risk on a 3-day call, before	after
Tankers and gas carriers	0.09%	1.50%	0.27%	4.4%
Bulk carriers	0.01%	1.64%	0.03%	4.8%

This distinction is routinely lost in reporting on the theatre. Because roughly half the exposed fleet had already withdrawn, the collapse in the denominator means per-vessel risk rose further than the raw casualty count implies, not less. Fewer ships are being hit than the headline tempo suggests only in the sense that there are far fewer ships present to hit.

The plainest statement of the same thing is the raw count. Of the 111 tankers and gas carriers recorded in the region between 15 and 27 July, ten were struck. One in eleven.

These are averages across the whole region and conceal considerable variation. A vessel lying at a loading terminal carries materially more exposure than one on passage, as Section 3 sets out.

3. Where the risk falls

Casualties fall into four distinct clusters. Exposure is heaviest close to the eastern loading terminals but is not confined to them.

Zone	Description	Casualties	Range from nearest Russian port
A	North-east basin: eastern loading terminals, approaches and anchorages	6	2 – 45 km
B	Kerch Strait approaches and adjacent waters	3	15 – 24 km
C	Open-sea transit corridor, central and southern basin	5	54 – 255 km
D	Sea of Azov	1	21 km

The heaviest concentration is at and immediately off the eastern loading terminals, where six casualties occurred and four of those within 2 km of one another. Vessels alongside, at anchor or drifting on terminal approaches are static, predictable and clustered, and were struck as such. Time spent stationary in that zone is the single greatest exposure in the record, and terminal suspensions are currently forcing vessels to spend more of it there.

The Kerch approaches form a chokepoint with little room for routeing flexibility, and three casualties occurred there in the first two days of the period.

Five casualties occurred in open water between 54 and 255 km from the nearest Russian port, two of them beyond 200 km and one well inside the Turkish exclusive economic zone. Distance from a Russian port reduces exposure but does not remove it, and no plausible port-centred exclusion zone would have covered the observed threat.

The Sea of Azov appears here with a single casualty, which understates it considerably. That theatre is recorded separately and in aggregate, frequently in batches of tens of vessels, and should be treated as a higher-intensity environment than these figures suggest.

4. What is being targeted

4.1 Vessel class

The most consequential change since 15 July is not the volume of attacks but the widening of the target set.

One bulk carrier was struck serving a Russian port in the six and a half months to 14 July. Five were struck in the twelve days that followed. Before 15 July this campaign was, in practice, a campaign against tankers; it no longer is. Any operator relying on the pattern of the first half of the year is working from a threat picture that has been overtaken.

Within the tanker set there remains one clear concentration: five crude oil tankers of between 151,700 and 163,100 tonnes deadweight were struck within four days, four of them at or immediately off the same eastern loading terminal, under four different flags. That reflects where that class of vessel is required to be.

4.2 Trade served

Exposure follows position and activity, not the ultimate destination or ownership of the cargo. Casualties since 15 July include vessels loading Russian crude for export, vessels loading non-Russian crude through the pipeline-consortium terminal, bulk carriers loading for Turkish, United States and South African destinations, and vessels in ballast inbound to load. The common factor is presence at or transit to a Russian Black Sea terminal.

This bears directly on how exposure should be assessed. A charterer screening a fixture by reference to whether the cargo serves Russian or Crimean interests will not identify the risk, because the casualty record contains cargoes that do neither. The relevant question is whether the vessel will be present in the area, and for how long.

4.3 Registry

Casualties since 15 July are spread across nine registries, the largest open registries, several minor registries associated with sanctions-evasive tonnage, and one national flag. No registry accounts for more than a third.

Once the volume of traffic under each registry is taken into account, no registry's record can be distinguished from the others. The most heavily represented flag shows a slightly higher figure than the rest, but the difference is well within what the small number of casualties would produce by chance alone, and the same held before 15 July.

The practical conclusion is that registry cannot be used to discriminate risk in this theatre, in either direction. No flag can be represented as safer and none as more exposed. Reflagging is not a mitigation. The evidence is sufficient to rule out a large registry effect but not a small one, and this should be re-tested as the casualty count grows.

4.4 Sanctions status, ownership and age

One of the sixteen vessels struck since 15 July carried a sanctions designation. Whatever the campaign's stated focus on sanctions-evasive tonnage, the vessels actually being hit are overwhelmingly not designated.

Beneficial ownership among casualties is mainstream: Greece, Türkiye, China, Bermuda, Germany and Vietnam. Deadweight ranges from 3,038 to 163,111 tonnes and build years from 1994 to 2026, including ships delivered in 2024 and 2026. Ownership in a reputable jurisdiction, membership of a mainstream P&I club, a modern hull and the absence of a designation did not correlate with immunity.

5. What happens when a vessel is hit

Of the vessels struck since 15 July, ten sustained damage to hull, machinery or steering in addition to blast damage, and five suffered fire or explosion. The characteristic outcome is a vessel that remains afloat but has lost manoeuvrability, or has a fire in the machinery space or accommodation.

Recorded human casualties in this trade are low: one death and five injuries, every injury classified as serious. This is consistent with the campaign's stated doctrine of disabling rather than sinking.

The exposure to plan against is therefore immobilisation and its consequences, salvage and towage, port of refuge, off-hire, cargo delay and possible pollution rather than total loss or mass casualty. That is a materially different planning assumption from the one appropriate to the Ukrainian corridor, where the same period produced eleven deaths across eight incidents.

6. The operating environment

Several conditions current at the assessment date affect a vessel in this trade whether or not it is attacked.

- **Loading suspended.** Russia's largest Black Sea oil terminal stopped loading tankers on 21 July and a neighbouring pipeline-consortium terminal suspended operations temporarily. Vessels arriving to load should expect delay, and that delay is spent in the highest-exposure zone in the record.
- **Night navigation restricted.** A temporary ban on movement between midnight and 05:00 local time was reported at a principal eastern port that ordinarily works around the clock.
- **Chokepoint degraded.** Shipping through the Don–Azov channel and the Kerch Strait was halted earlier in July. Ukrainian sources claim the Kerch crossing has lost around three-quarters of its capacity; the claim is unverified but is consistent with the concentration of casualties there.
- **War-risk cover repricing.** Additional premiums for Black Sea transits rose above 1% of vessel value in the week to 21 July, with one broking source indicating around 1.5%, and underwriters are repricing on a very short cycle.
- **Tonnage withdrawing.** Tanker presence in the region fell by two thirds and bulk carrier presence by half between the two periods, against a fall of only 16% in total merchant presence. The contraction is confined to the classes being struck. Available tonnage for these trades is correspondingly constrained.
- **Political pressure on targeting.** Kazakhstan has protested at strikes affecting an export route carrying non-Russian crude, and the United States has reportedly cautioned Ukraine against striking vessels not connected to Russia. This is the most plausible near-term constraint on the campaign's breadth.

7. Shipping serving Ukrainian ports

A second, co-located threat set exists and is excluded from every figure elsewhere in this assessment. Vessels serving Ukrainian ports and the Ukrainian maritime corridor face Russian attack, principally off Odesa and Chornomorsk and in the Danube approaches.

The profile differs sharply. Eight casualties in the same window produced eleven deaths and thirteen injuries, against one death and five injuries across sixteen casualties in the Russia-serving trade. One vessel struck on 19 July subsequently sank. The Russia-serving threat is high-frequency and largely non-lethal, delivered by uncrewed systems; the Ukraine-serving threat is less frequent and markedly more lethal, delivered in part by cruise missiles against vessels alongside.

The two cannot be planned for on the same assumptions, and merging them, as several public incident feeds do, produces a picture that is wrong for both.

8. Outlook and indicators

The elevated risk level should be assumed to persist into August. The campaign is declared, resourced, directed at a trade rather than at discrete targets, and its commander has stated it will continue indefinitely. Tempo showed no decay across the observed window and the operating restrictions remained in force at the assessment date.

The following would indicate material change:

- Any recovery in tanker or bulk carrier presence in the region. This is the most informative single indicator available, because it reflects the judgement of operators with money at stake.
- Resumption of normal loading at the eastern export terminals and lifting of night navigation restrictions.
- Any narrowing of Ukrainian targeting to designated tonnage only, which would follow from sustained third-State pressure and would materially change the position for non-designated vessels.
- Extension of strikes further west or south, particularly deeper into the Turkish exclusive economic zone or towards the Bosphorus approaches.
- A shift from disabling towards sinkings or significant loss of life in this trade, which would change the consequence profile at Section 5 and the insurance response with it.
- Further movement in war-risk additional premiums, which functions as a real-time market view.

9. Recommendations

Framed for an owner, operator or charterer with tonnage employed in, or contemplating employment in, this trade. They are deliberately flag-neutral and not specific to any port.

- Treat the eastern and central basin, the Kerch approaches and the Bosphorus transit corridor as a single elevated-risk area. Mitigation built around port approaches alone leaves roughly a third of the observed threat uncovered.
- Minimise stationary time. Time at anchor, drifting or alongside on the eastern terminals is the greatest single exposure in the record. Where loading suspensions make delay unavoidable, consider waiting clear of the terminal approaches rather than on them.
- Do not rely on registry, ownership jurisdiction, P&I membership, vessel age, size or the absence of a sanctions designation. None correlates with immunity.
- Bulk carrier operators should not rely on the pattern of the first half of 2026. That class was not previously being struck and now is.
- Plan for immobilisation rather than loss. Confirm towage and salvage contingency, port of refuge options and damage-control readiness for impacts on the superstructure, machinery space and steering gear, which is the characteristic damage pattern.
- Review war-risk cover before fixing. Premiums exceeded 1% of vessel value during the period and are being repriced on a short cycle. Verify current terms, breach-of-warranty provisions, held-covered wording and any Kerch Strait or Sea of Azov exclusions.
- Review manning and crew protection against a stand-off attack profile: minimum manning during terminal operations, muster arrangements away from the accommodation block and engine room, and drills for fire in those spaces.
- Re-test at the end of August 2026. A thirteen-day observation window and sixteen casualties will not carry a decision far into the autumn.

Annex A — Casualties, 15 to 23 July 2026

Vessels serving Russian ports. Vessel identities withheld. Zones as defined at Section 3. Range is distance to the nearest Russian Black Sea or Azov port.

Date	Flag	Type	DWT	Built	Zone	Range (km)	Sanctioned
15 Jul	Panama	LPG carrier	4,105	1996	B	15	No
15 Jul	Singapore	Bulk carrier	63,563	2026	B	23	No
16 Jul	Panama	LPG carrier	5,599	1994	C	255	No
16 Jul	Panama	Bulk carrier	28,498	2003	B	24	No
16 Jul	Liberia	Crude oil tanker	—	—	—	not released	No
17 Jul	Malta	Bulk carrier	58,000	2011	A	45	No
17 Jul	Liberia	Crude oil tanker	158,645	2011	A	7	No
17 Jul	Liberia	Bulk carrier	40,200	2024	C	54	No
18 Jul	Barbados	Crude oil tanker	151,736	2003	A	29	No
19 Jul	Liberia	Crude oil tanker	163,111	2022	A	2	No
19 Jul	Marshall Is.	Crude oil tanker	158,000	2021	A	2	No
19 Jul	Guinea-Bissau	General cargo	6,933	2004	C	102	No
20 Jul	Cameroon	Crude oil tanker	156,760	2010	A	2	Yes
21 Jul	Panama	Chemical/oil tanker	3,038	2000	D	21	No
22 Jul	Türkiye	Bulk carrier	36,075	2011	C	223	No
23 Jul	Panama	Chemical/oil tanker	34,578	2002	C	64	No

Eight further casualties in the same window involved vessels serving Ukrainian ports or the Ukrainian maritime corridor and are excluded; they are summarised at Section 7.

Annex B — Method, sources and limitations

How the figures were produced

- A single consolidated casualty record was built covering 8 January to 23 July 2026, combining a year-to-date maritime security incident log with a detailed casualty database covering 9 to 23 July. Duplicate entries for the same vessel within four days were treated as one event. All figures in this assessment are drawn from that consolidated record.
- Incidents were classified by the trade served — Russia-serving or Ukraine-serving — on position, route and vessel employment, and not according to the category under which a source record filed them. A number of source entries were filed under the wrong attacker. Naval, paramilitary, fishing and harbour craft were excluded, as were incidents outside the assessment area.
- Exposure was measured as vessel-days recorded by AIS inside a single area covering the eastern and central Black Sea, the Kerch Strait and the Sea of Azov, applied identically to both periods: approximately 61,600 vessel-days before 15 July and 3,400 after. A vessel-day is one vessel present for twenty-four hours.
- Risk per day is casualties divided by vessel-days. Risk across a call compounds that figure over the length of stay. Each figure carries a range of true values consistent with the number of casualties observed, calculated on an exact Poisson basis at the 95% level; where the ranges for the two periods do not overlap, the difference is treated as established. For every headline figure in this assessment they do not overlap.
- Casualty vessels were confirmed present in the corresponding traffic record before any rate was calculated.

Limitations

This assessment reflects a thirteen-day observation window and a small number of incidents. It is sufficient to establish the direction and approximate scale of the change, and to rule out large effects from registry, sanctions status and ownership; it is not sufficient to rule out small ones. It should be re-tested as the casualty count grows.

Sources

- Proprietary: year-to-date Black Sea maritime security incident log, 8 January – 23 July 2026; casualty database, 9 – 23 July 2026; AIS vessel-movement and area-dwell records, 1 January – 27 July 2026.
- Open source, consulted 27 July 2026: Bloomberg (terminal suspensions and navigation restrictions, as reported); The Insurer (war-risk pricing, 21 July); Reuters, Kyiv Independent, Kyiv Post, Ukrainska Pravda, Euromaidan Press and United24 Media (campaign reporting, operation naming and Ukrainian official claims); International Maritime Organization statement of 13 July; Russian Ministry of Defence navigational warning of 22 July, as reported.

This assessment is based on the records identified above and on open-source reporting available at the assessment date. It reflects a thirteen-day observation window and a small number of incidents, and should be re-tested at the end of August 2026. It is provided for general information and for the recipient's internal risk-management purposes. It is not insurance, legal or investment advice, and does not constitute a recommendation to undertake or refrain from any particular voyage or fixture. No reliance should be placed on it in relation to any specific vessel, voyage or fixture without a current, individually scoped assessment.